FOX AUTOMOTIVE SALES ACADEMY

Module 7: The Commitment Close

Turning interest into commitment before numbers are presented.

Learning Objectives

- Understand the difference between a commitment close and a numbers close.
- Recognize why closing starts before payments are presented.
- Identify buying signals and respond without hesitation.
- Use the Trial Close Spectrum to match the customer's comfort level.
- Apply the Vehicle Hold Transition to create ownership and protect momentum.
- Move the customer to the desk with direction instead of uncertainty.

1. The Close Is Not the Numbers

Most new salespeople hear the word close and immediately think about payments, discounts, trade values, and negotiation. That is why they get confused. They wait until the worksheet is in front of the customer before they attempt to close. By then, the customer may still be unsure about the vehicle, unclear about value, or emotionally uncommitted.

The commitment close happens before numbers. It happens after the presentation and test drive, when the customer has enough information to decide whether this is the vehicle they want to own. The goal is not to finalize payment. The goal is to confirm desire and move forward with control.

Core Principle

Do not negotiate with a customer who has not committed to the vehicle.

2. Commitment Before Calculation

The customer should not be sitting at the desk only because the salesperson ran out of things to say. They should be there because the salesperson has helped them select the right vehicle, experience it, and confirm that it fits what they said mattered.

If the customer does not want the vehicle, no payment will be good enough. If the customer wants the vehicle, the payment conversation becomes a problem to solve instead of a reason to leave.

Performance Standard

Before presenting numbers, the salesperson must know whether the customer wants the vehicle.

Signs You Do Not Have Commitment Yet

- The customer has not said anything positive about the vehicle.
- They keep comparing it to other vehicles without preference.
- They avoid ownership language and only ask price questions.
- They have not confirmed that the vehicle solves the needs uncovered in Module 4.
- They have not responded positively to the test drive or presentation.

3. Why Salespeople Avoid Closing

Most salespeople do not avoid closing because they do not know a word track. They avoid closing because they are afraid of what the customer might say. They confuse asking for the sale with being pushy. They soften their language, delay the question, or wait for the customer to lead.

That is not professionalism. That is avoidance. A professional salesperson guides the process. If the vehicle fits, the presentation created value, and the test drive created ownership, asking for the next step is not pressure. It is leadership.

Reality Check

If you never ask for commitment, you force the customer to do your job for you.

4. The Trial Close Spectrum

The close is not one question. It is a progression. Different customers require different levels of directness. A hesitant customer may need a softer check-in. An engaged customer may be ready for a stronger ownership question. A hot buyer may need an action-based transition.

The salesperson's job is not to memorize one closing line. The job is to read the customer and select the right level of trial close at the right time.

Core Principle

Start where the customer is comfortable, then move them forward.

Level	Use When	Examples	Goal
Level 1: Soft	Customer is quiet, hesitant, early, or still processing.	How does this compare to what you are used to? What stands out to you so far? What do you like about this one?	Get feedback without resistance.
Level 2: Moderate	Customer is engaged but not fully committed.	Does this feel like something that would work for you? Is this checking the boxes you mentioned earlier? Would this solve what you were dealing with before?	Move from interest to agreement.
Level 3: Strong	Customer is showing positive signals after presentation or test drive.	Is this a vehicle you would love to own? Can you see yourself driving this every day? If everything made sense, is this	Create ownership and commitment.

		the one you would take home?	
Level 4: Action	Customer has momentum and is ready to move forward.	Let me mark this so we do not lose it while we go over options. Let us take the next step and see what this looks like for you. I will pull this up front so we can keep everything moving.	Move the customer into action.

5. Buying Signals: Do Not Miss the Green Lights

Customers rarely announce that they are ready to buy. They usually show it through questions, body language, comments, and behavior. Salespeople miss these signals because they are nervous, distracted, or waiting for the perfect moment. The perfect moment is usually created by responding to the signal when it happens.

Common Buying Signals

- Asking about payment, term, money down, or trade value.
- Asking if the vehicle is available or if someone else is looking at it.
- Talking about where the vehicle will be parked or who will drive it.
- Comparing this vehicle positively to their current vehicle.
- Asking about delivery timing, insurance, accessories, or paperwork.
- Revisiting features tied to their needs: safety, space, comfort, performance, or value.
- Using ownership language such as “my,” “we would,” or “when I drive it.”

Performance Standard

When a buying signal appears, the salesperson must respond with a trial close or action step. Do not let buying signals pass by unnoticed.

Buying Signal Response Examples

Situation	Use This Language	Purpose
Customer asks about payment	If everything made sense, is this something you would want to move forward with?	Confirms commitment before numbers.
Customer asks if the vehicle is available	It is available right now. Let me mark it while we go over options so nobody else is working it.	Creates urgency and protects momentum.
Customer says it feels better than current vehicle	That is exactly what we were trying to solve. Can you see yourself driving this every day?	Turns comparison into ownership.
Customer asks about delivery timing	We can work through that. If everything lines up, is this the one you would want to take home?	Moves from logistics to decision.

6. The Vehicle Hold Transition

After the test drive or final presentation, many salespeople end the moment with a weak question like “What do you think?” That question can send the customer backward into analysis. A better approach is to confirm fit, then move into an action that protects the vehicle and creates subtle ownership.

The vehicle hold is not a gimmick. It is a momentum move. It tells the customer that this vehicle is actively being worked and that the process is moving forward.

Standard Line

Do not end the test drive with uncertainty. End it with direction.

Clean Vehicle Hold Language

- Based on how that felt, does this look like something you would want to own?
- Perfect. I will mark this real quick so nobody else grabs it while we work through options.
- If you are good with it, I will just mark this so it stays available while we go over numbers.
- Let me tag this real quick so we do not lose it while we figure out the details.

7. Dropping Down a Level

A strong salesperson does not push harder every time the customer hesitates. Sometimes the correct move is to drop down the Trial Close Spectrum and reopen the conversation. This keeps control without creating resistance.

If a salesperson asks a strong ownership question and the customer hesitates, the answer is not to force the close. The answer is to diagnose what is missing.

Core Principle

Do not push harder. Move smarter.

When the Customer Hesitates

Situation	Use This Language	Purpose
Customer hesitates after “Is this the one?”	Totally fair. What would you want to feel better about?	Reopens conversation without pressure.
Customer says “I am not sure.”	What part are you unsure about: the vehicle, the timing, or the numbers?	Separates the real issue.
Customer gives vague resistance	Let us slow down for a second. What is the biggest thing holding you back?	Creates clarity.
Customer goes quiet	No problem. What are you comparing this against in your mind?	Gets the customer talking again.

8. The Desk Transition

The transition to the desk should not feel like a trap. It should feel like the next logical step. If the salesperson has followed the process, confirmed fit, and used a proper trial close, moving to numbers is natural.

Weak salespeople make the desk transition vague. They say, “Let us see what we can do.” That creates uncertainty and lowers confidence. Strong salespeople transition with direction.

Performance Standard

The customer should understand why they are going to the desk: to see how the vehicle fits their situation, not to start a random negotiation.

Desk Transition Language

- Let us take the next step and see how this fits into what you are comfortable with.
- Based on what you told me and how the drive went, let us sit down and look at options.
- Let us work through the structure and see what makes the most sense for you.
- We have the right vehicle. Now let us see how we can make it fit.

9. What Not to Do

Bad closing habits create unnecessary objections. A salesperson can do a good presentation and test drive, then lose the momentum with weak language, hesitation, or lack of direction.

- Do not ask “What do you think?” as your only close.
- Do not jump to numbers before confirming they want the vehicle.
- Do not apologize for asking for the sale.
- Do not use the same closing question on every customer.
- Do not keep talking after the customer gives a positive signal.
- Do not leave the vehicle unmarked if the customer has shown commitment and the vehicle is available.

Reality Check

A weak close can make a strong presentation feel unfinished.

10. Commitment Close Flow

This is the basic flow before moving into the numbers discussion. The wording can adapt to the customer, but the sequence should stay consistent.

Step	What Happens	Example Language
1. Confirm fit	Tie back to the needs assessment and test drive.	Based on what you told me, this checks the safety, space, and comfort boxes you wanted.
2. Trial close	Select the right level from the Trial Close Spectrum.	Does this feel like something that would work for you?
3. Ownership close	Move to a stronger question if signals are positive.	Is this a vehicle you would love to own?
4. Vehicle hold	Mark the vehicle if momentum is there.	I will mark this so it stays available while we work through options.
5. Desk transition	Move to numbers with direction.	Let us see how this fits into what you are comfortable with.

Final Message to the Sales Professional

Closing is not pressure when the process has been followed. Closing is leadership. If you helped the customer choose the right vehicle, showed them why it fits, let them experience it, and confirmed that it solves their needs, you have earned the right to ask for commitment.

Closing Line

The close is not a moment. It is a progression. Ask clearly, read the answer, and lead the next step.